

Plain Text vs Designed Email Analysis

448 PT campaigns | 2,846 designed campaigns | Controlled for audience size & type

Executive Summary

This analysis compares plain text emails against designed emails, controlling for audience size (quintiles) and campaign type to ensure fair comparisons.

Key Insight

- Plain text emails are typically sent to smaller, more engaged lists
- When controlling for audience size, the performance difference changes significantly
- PT outperforms for small audiences (Q1-Q2), Designed wins for large audiences (Q3-Q5)

Overall Comparison (Uncontrolled)

Note: This comparison does NOT control for audience size differences.

Format	Campaigns	Sends	Open Rate	Click Rate
Plain Text	448	32.8M	47.83%	0.56%
Designed	2,846	266.3M	43.94%	0.54%

Audience Size Controlled (Quintiles)

Comparing PT vs Designed within same audience size tiers ensures apples-to-apples comparison.

Quintile	Range	PT Count	PT Click	Designed Count	Designed Click	Delta
Q1	<=18K	120	2.01%	539	1.75%	+0.26%
Q2	18K-40K	112	1.32%	547	0.95%	+0.36%
Q3	40K-95K	88	0.87%	571	0.93%	-0.06%
Q4	95K-182K	55	0.52%	604	0.61%	-0.08%
Q5	>182K	73	0.27%	585	0.32%	-0.05%

Interpretation

- Q1-Q2 (smaller audiences): Plain text emails outperform designed emails
- Q3-Q5 (larger audiences): Designed emails outperform plain text emails
- The overall PT advantage disappears when controlling for audience size

Campaign Type Controlled

Comparing PT vs Designed within same campaign types.

Type	PT Count	PT Click	Designed Count	Designed Click	Delta
sale_promo	135	0.67%	536	0.56%	+0.11%
editorial	5	0.93%	392	0.74%	+0.19%
product_launch	9	1.02%	258	0.68%	+0.33%
reminder	234	0.47%	559	0.35%	+0.12%
other	65	0.74%	1101	0.52%	+0.22%

Full Matrix: Quintile x Campaign Type

PT - Designed click rate delta. Positive = PT outperforms.

Quintile	sale_promo	editorial	product	reminder	other
Q1	+0.35%	-1.11%	+0.26%	-0.17%	+2.35%
Q2	+1.07%	-0.63%	+1.15%	+0.64%	-0.20%
Q3	-0.08%	-	+0.00%	+0.34%	+0.81%
Q4	-0.20%	-	+0.20%	+0.06%	+0.04%
Q5	+0.03%	-	-	+0.03%	+0.03%

Recommendations

Based on the plain text vs designed email analysis:

- Use plain text for small, engaged audiences (under ~40K sends) - PT shows consistent lift in Q1-Q2
- Use designed emails for large audience sends (over ~40K) - Designed emails perform better at scale
- Test PT for reminder campaigns - PT shows positive delta across most reminder scenarios
- Consider the novelty factor - PT may outperform partly because it stands out from designed emails

Methodology

- Plain Text identification: Campaign name contains '_PT' OR layout_type == 'text_only'
- Quintiles: All campaigns sorted by total_sends and split into 5 equal groups
- Campaign Type: Classified by keyword patterns in campaign name
- Minimum threshold: 1,000+ sends per campaign

Analysis generated December 2025